

Positivism and Materialism

[Positivisme og Materialisme]

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Positivism and Materialism.

With Particular Reference to *Maudsley's* Lecture: "On the Relation between Mind and Body and between Mental Illnesses and Other Disorders of the Nervous System". (Translated in "Ugeskrift for Læger". Sept.-Oct. 1870^{*)}).

1.

It is only in the modern age that one can speak of sciences. Antiquity and the Middle Ages really knew only one, all-encompassing science. The reason for this lies in the essentially different standpoints from which existence can be conceived. The one chief standpoint is that of the whole, the one, final end in which everything gathers together for comprehending thought, and which must therefore be the concluding point and summit of every worldview. Antiquity and the Middle Ages adopt *this* standpoint alone, and therefore for them science is only one. From the idea of the whole, which in antiquity is essentially seen as the idea of the beautiful, in the Middle Ages as the idea of the good, one then seeks to derive the whole system of conditions that forms the foundation for the actualization of the idea; the conditions are seen as contained in the idea itself, without any felt need for a distinct inquiry with distinct laws and methods in order to investigate them. In the modern age, by contrast, thought has turned especially toward [194] the conditions as such; it has seen the impossibility of arriving at the cognition of them except through a peculiar inquiry occupied specifically with them, and little by little, therefore, one circle of conditions after another detached itself from the great whole as the object of a single, self-contained science with its own method and its own principles. Experience is installed in its rights and brought under exact laws.

This dissolution of the abstract unity of science could not take place without resistance on the part of those who believed that with this absolute unity they would lose all scientific unity in cognition. At the beginning of the modern age, to be sure, it was chiefly the medieval Aristotelians who opposed empirical science; and for them the ideal of unity had stiffened into a faith in authority that let them set Aristotelian pronouncements above the testimony of their own eyes^{*)}. But at the beginning of this century the speculative

^{*)}Later published as a separate offprint.

^{*)}*Galilæi* (*Dialogus de systemate mundi* cited by *Feuerbach*: Pierre Bayle. 2nd ed., p. 213) relates that when a famous physician in Venice had demonstrated in a lecture that the largest nerve trunk issued from

idealism in Germany attempted once again to develop everything from a single starting point, the idea. Schelling declared that Baco had corrupted philosophy, and Newton physics! Yet nothing has been able to halt the victorious advance of empirical science; step by step it has pressed forward and has encompassed everything in the net of the exact method.

This great power of the spirit has not escaped the danger that, as the ancients so profoundly teach us, threatens every fortunate and victorious power: that of overstepping its limit and its justification. But it must be stressed that the limit here is not easy to [195] draw. In this domain there can be no question of outward, finite limits. The limit must lie originally in the very principle from which one proceeds. Modern empirical science does not ask about the ideal significance and worth of its objects; it seeks only to determine their elements and inner connection; it aims at a *how* and not at a *why*. But then it follows of itself that the result, too, can be only a cognition of the elements and their mutual connection, — that, therefore, a total, concluding cognition of existence requires as its supplement a cognition that holds fast to the ideal standpoint and proceeds from the total unity. Only the interaction and union of these standpoints can lead to the goal; they are the two ends that must be joined for the circle to be closed. Empirical science therefore oversteps its limit when it believes straightway that it has solved the *whole* problem of existence. It holds only one of the threads in its hand.

At this point lies the germ of materialism. The idea, the total unity, is the determination of form, over against which the system of conditions represents the determination of matter, of the material, and the peculiarity of materialism now consists in overlooking the independence of form, of the idea, and deriving it solely from the connection of matter. It regards matter, then, not merely as the condition of form, but as the cause of form. To the uncritical eye the materialistic tendency thus lies so close to empirical science that it is no wonder that in our day it dares to regard itself as the latter's only legitimate daughter. Among natural scientists who do not have a sharp and sure eye for the essence of their science, materialism readily makes its appearance as soon as they seek to raise themselves from the detail of special investigations to a more comprehensive total view (as a rule in a very popular form); they forget that for such a view other elements come into consideration than those that the single science can encompass. This belongs among [196] the unfortunate consequences of the division of labor in the domain of cognition.

the brain, he asked an Aristotelian who was present whether he still believed that the nerves originated in the heart and not in the brain; the latter then answered that he would have declared himself convinced by what he now saw before his eyes, if Aristotle had not expressly taught the opposite: *Eqvidem ita aperte rem oculis subjecisti, ut, nisi textus Aristotelicus aperte nervos ex corde deducens obstaret, in sententiam tuam protractus me fuisses!*

Yet it is not only where the final, concluding total view is concerned that the materialistic tendency, as we have characterized it, can assert itself. Within empirical science itself, too, the same relation between condition and cause, matter and form, repeats itself; *there*, too, then, lies a possibility of opposite directions. The more the great advances of modern science in every domain are owed to the exact conception of the conditions, the nearer lies the misunderstanding that the thing itself is nothing but the conditions. Materialism is the reaction against the dualism of earlier times, a protest against the external separation of the essence from its conditions. What it combats is really only the opinion that there should be hidden, as it were, behind the phenomena a certain mystical force that was independent of the conditions. It therefore strives to lead everything back to the elementary and to let it arise from the composition of the elementary. The higher, more concrete science must then constantly struggle against encroachments from the lower, more abstract and elementary one. In physics that direction is termed materialistic which denies the peculiarity of the individual mechanical forces and regards them only as special forms of elementary motion. If this is extended further, not only will chemistry be dissolved into mechanical physics, but physiology too into chemistry, psychology into physiology. The concrete and peculiar is at every point to be seen only as the product of the abstract, general conditions, the individual unity only as a composition of mechanically acting elements.

We are speaking here only of the materialistic *tendency*. Materialism cannot be carried through completely. Pure matter would be one with pure nothing, from which nothing can come. The essence of materialism lies rather in the relative, as indeed the determination of matter is always relative, since what is matter in one respect is form [197] in another. The justification of relative materialism lies, according to the foregoing, in expressing the truth that matter explains form *insofar as* the latter rests on and depends on the former. But when the tendency goes further, the self-contradiction comes plainly to light.

For form, the idea of the whole, does not come in from outside, but shows itself within the very world of conditions. It finds its particular expression — although it is present everywhere — where a peculiar circle of laws and phenomena unfolds on the basis of more abstract and elementary presuppositions, and where therefore the domain of a new and higher science begins. These different circles form, as it were, a nodal line, where the quantitative transitions condense into qualitative centers, from which the movement, through continual quantifying, constantly passes on to other and yet other

nodal points^{*)}. Materialism now grounds itself here on an optical illusion, inasmuch [198] as, because the qualitative can be determined through quantifying, it believes that the qualitative in itself rests only on differences of magnitude. But since those nodal points actually exist in existence, the materialistic tendency constantly comes to contradict its own principle, comes to smuggle in qualitative determinations while it believes it is explaining everything quantitatively.

Viewed theoretically, then, materialism in our time is easy to explain; it is bound up with what, viewed from another side, constitutes the greatness and strength of our time. It is a phenomenon of the time, whose essence and origin one need only make clear to oneself in order to be able to overcome it. In practice materialism no doubt appears with greater tenacity and strength; yet here too the same must hold. From the theological side materialism has been summarily condemned as heresy, inasmuch as it is regarded not as an error in cognition, but as a doctrine formed by the evil will for its own extenuation^{*)}.

^{*)}Compare with this what *Lewes* says in his biography of Goethe about the latter's theory of colors. It is mistaken as a contribution to optics, because it disregards the exact quantitative method. "Without the free control of the scales the chemical experiment can never become quantitative, and without quantitative knowledge there can be no chemical science, strictly speaking, but only qualitative, i.e. approximate, knowledge. No degree of observation can make observation exact when it cannot be measured. Though one should observe falling bodies for all eternity, without mathematics one will never arrive at the law of gravitation." But on the other hand Goethe's theory of colors is very valuable when one looks only to the conception of colors as such, without regard to their mechanical conditions. "For artists and physiologists, that is to say for those who have an interest chiefly in the phenomena of color as sense impressions, and who demand qualitative rather than quantitative knowledge, his works have great value". — On this it is to be remarked that it is only from an abstract quantitative standpoint that the qualitative can be made one with the approximate. According to *Lewes's* own characterization, by contrast, the qualitative designates the phenomenon as a whole and the significance, the worth, that it has as such, and this becomes here, where colors are in question, one with the ideal, psychological and aesthetic significance. Naturally the different standpoints cannot be kept absolutely apart from one another; it is precisely this that is designated by the expression nodal line.

^{*)}Cf. "Briefe gegen den Materialismus von Dr. F. Fabri, Missionsinspektor". 2nd ed., p. 216: "Die Lehre der Materialisten von einer mekanischen Denknöthwendigkeit ist im Grunde nichts als das Feigenblatt ihrer die moralische Verantwortlichkeit läugnenden Unfreiheit des Willens. Der verkehrte Wille vollendet sich in der verkehrten Theorie". The author holds, namely, that all knowing proceeds from an immediate faith, which in turn is determined by man's will. He thereby really makes his whole book superfluous, while at the same time it becomes consistent when he attributes unethical motives to his opponents, which he drives to a fanatical extreme. Thus he mentions in a note that a "Verein badischer Aerzte zur Förderung der Staatsarzneikunde" had named Büchner, author of the well-known materialistic work "Kraft und Stoff", its honorary member. It would not, he adds (p. 27), be uninteresting to learn something about the motives that guided the society for "Staatsarzneikunde" in that step: "Doch wir erinnern uns so eben, daß der Verfasser von "Kraft und Stoff" die Abtreibung der Leibesfrucht als ein Recht der Mutter wieder vindicirt hat, und daß er die Freiheit des Willens und also die sittliche Zurechnungsfähigkeit mit Herrn Vogt läugnet! Es kann aber nicht in Abrede gestellt werden, daß dies Behauptungen sind von solcher Tragweite, die allerdings nicht nur die gesammte gerichtliche Medicin, sondern unser ganzes Rechtsbewußtseins und alle sociale Ordnungen in Grund und Boden reformiren müßten. Und bei der Lage des Falls bleibt wenigstens bis zur Führung des Gegenbeweises (!) nichts übrig, als anzunehmen, jener Carlsruher Verein habe in Herrn Büchner den verkannten Apostel einer solchen schönen Zukunft ehren wollen". The materialists did not handle their opponents gently, but one would search their writings in vain for such venomous insinuations as the one cited here. I hardly need remark that Büchner by no means defends abortion;

[199] For philosophical criticism, on the other hand, the practical corrective stands in close connection with the theoretical and does not appear in isolation. Thereby criticism also becomes able to acknowledge what is justified in the materialistic tendency.

In our day a grand attempt has been made to lay what is justified in the materialistic tendency at the foundation of a whole worldview. So-called positivism, whose founder is *Auguste Comte*, and which has won wide adherence among the French and English philosophers and natural scientists, aims to carry through a philosophy grounded immediately on the principle of empirical science, — a “positive” philosophy, because it is supported by the positive sciences. A consideration of this direction will demonstrate more clearly than general reflections the peculiar character of relative materialism. *Maudsley’s* interesting lectures, which have rightly attracted attention in a wide circle, belong, [200] as regards the whole underlying train of thought, to the general positivist direction.

2.

Auguste Comte sets his positive philosophy in opposition to the theological and metaphysical philosophizing of earlier times. At the first, imperfect stage of consciousness man sees everything in nature as proceeding from a cause similar to the one that brings about his own movements and actions, that is, from a thought and will lying behind the phenomena. Since he does not yet have any clear consciousness of necessary lawfulness, he sees the will at work in nature as an arbitrary will, which does with things just as it pleases; and since this in turn presupposes a higher power than the human, which has no absolute dominion over nature, that arbitrary will becomes for man the divine omnipotence, to which he relates himself through religion. But through closer, sustained occupation with the phenomena there gradually arises the cognition that it is not absolute arbitrariness but fixed order and regularity that reign in their course. In place of the almighty, personal will, the inner essence of things then appears to consciousness as the real cause. Behind the phenomena one imagines hidden forces, in which their final explanation is sought; each of these forces rules in its circle of phenomena, and the system of all the forces forms an inner world which produces and sustains the outer, visible world. In place of that world of gods in which the immediate consciousness sought the explanation of phenomena, there is here, then, set a world of metaphysical beings (*entités métaphysiques*). It is no longer dryads that animate the trees and guide their

he merely mentions, in order to show how moral representations vary at different times, that while we regard it as a crime, the Romans found nothing immoral in it. It is Fabri himself who, in his zeal for the “mission” he has taken upon himself against materialism, finds in this an “assertion of abortion as a right of the mother”!

growth and life, but the cause of plant as well as of animal life is sought in a “vegetative soul” or a “life force”. The analogy with human consciousness recedes further here. Yet it is common to the religious and the metaphysical stage of consciousness that they both explain the outer by the inner, that they make man’s essence the basis for the explanation of the world, instead of conversely explaining man by the world.

»Le véritable esprit général de toute philosophie théologique ou métaphysique consiste [201] à prendre pour principe, dans l’explication des phénomènes du monde extérieur, notre sentiment immédiat des phénomènes humains; tandis que, au contraire, la philosophie positive est toujours caractérisé, non moins profondément, par la subordination nécessaire et rationnelle de la conception de l’homme à celle du monde« (Auguste Comte: Cours de philosophie positive. 2^{ème} éd. Tome III. p. 188).

The third period of consciousness is marked by the dominion of the positive, scientific method. Only because the religious and the metaphysical consciousness proceeded from the essence of man could they suppose that they attained a cognition of the essence and causes of things, an insight into the origin and destination of the world. Thought renounces this once it has arrived at »l’état positif«. It now keeps to the positive, that is to say, to the factually given: »positif, c’est à dire fondé sur des faits bien constatés«. But the factually given is only the phenomena. The sole task of thought is then to find their actual laws, that is to say, the invariable relations in which they succeed one another and resemble one another. It is, on the other hand, impossible to know their nature and essence in and for themselves. The essence in and for itself would be the unconditioned and absolute; but the positive is always conditioned and relative. Positive philosophy must therefore set up as its absolute fundamental principle that we can cognize nothing absolute.

What Comte calls »la loi des trois états« thus leads us into the peculiar essence of positivism. But closer determinations prove to be necessary. We cognize only the positive, i.e. (as Comte determines it) the relative, the conditioned. But does this mean that only the relative is, that no absolute principle *exists*, or does it mean only that we cannot *cognize* it? When everything we cognize is conditioned, is that to say that everything is only conditions, so that the conditioned is only the derived property of the conditions? In other words, there lies in the principle of positivism a possibility of skepticism as well [202] as of materialism.

Since Comte rejects all cognition of inner causes, of the essence and principle of things, his endeavor aims only at discovering the laws of phenomena, i.e. the conditions under which they arise. These laws or “general facts” (*faits généraux*), which hold for a

particular circle of phenomena, point back in turn to more general relations, of which they are only a particular form, and by thus always going back one comes at last from the concrete, intricate and composite phenomena to the simplest, most elementary and therefore most general laws. The mathematical laws embrace all spheres of existence, because they presuppose solely the pure relations of magnitude. »*La loi des trois états*« is here found completely realized: mathematics has long been a positive science. This does not, however, hold of the other sciences. Here particular principles are still always presupposed which are not reduced to simple positive phenomena or relations between phenomena. The completion of positivism *then* depends on this happening: that every peculiarity, every particular principle, be traced back to elementary presuppositions, and that these in turn be seen to proceed from the preceding, more abstract and therefore more comprehensive circle of laws. Each such circle, to be sure, always presupposes a method of experience of its own; but it cannot become systematic except by being derived from the more elementary circles.

What is indicated here goes in actuality beyond what is contained in the original program of positivism. Positivism must necessarily cease where the “positive” ends, and this happens as soon as the factual connection of the phenomena ends. The law Comte believes he has found, that the most general properties, which hold in the widest extension, are at the same time the most elementary and abstract, — a law which, as has rightly been remarked, is only the well-known logical proposition of the inverse [203] relation between the content of a concept and its extension⁹⁾ — this law contains no guarantee that the real (“positive”) explanation of phenomena could be found by always going back from the concrete and combined to the abstract and elementary. Comte has here, without further ado, transferred a logical relation to the real and positive, and has thereby placed himself at a standpoint similar to that of speculative philosophy, which derives the real from the logical. He here explains, to use his own words, the world by man, not man by the world.

The task he has set himself is to develop the fundamental concepts on which all our thinking and cognition rest, and he declares expressly that these fundamental concepts are not themselves grounded on any “preceding intellectual system”. But in the use he makes of that logical law he has an unconscious presupposition which is not drawn into the investigation. Here positivism then shows itself as dogmatism, and thereby passes

⁹⁾The content of a concept is the marks it specifies; its extension is everything to which these marks apply and which therefore falls under the concept. Now the greater the content (the more marks the concept specifies), the smaller the extension (the individuals that possess the concept’s marks and so can be brought under it). E.g. the concept animal — the concept horse: the latter contains more marks, but embraces fewer individuals than the former.

at the same time over into materialism. If one has granted that the logical proposition of the inverse relation between the content and extension of a concept can be applied immediately in the explanation of nature, then one has thereby granted the materialistic principle itself. But in this immediate application it is overlooked that the proposition undergoes a considerable change by being transferred in this way to the domain of nature. Logically seen, the abstract concept is the higher, insofar as it includes the more concrete concepts within it; but if one does not remain standing at a purely formal mode of consideration, the higher concept must be developed in such a way that it [204] does not merely arise by subtraction of the individual characteristic marks, but contains these within itself as possibilities, as moments, so that it gives the final, concluding explanation of the concrete, over against which it has the advantage of not being bound to the individual and finite, and yet, ideally seen, of including this within itself. The return from the higher concept, now not more abstract but more concrete, to the lower, more limited one does not then take place by a mere addition of the individual specific characteristic marks; rather, these are developed from the former as particular, relative expressions of it. As Comte conceives the higher concept and applies it in the explanation of phenomena, it is the merely abstract general concept, emptied by the subtraction of the particular. He thus regards the organic merely as a special case of the chemical, etc. — every phenomenon in the last instance as a special case of the mathematical. But how then can he make the transition from the general to the particular? Right at the transition from mathematics to physics the question of matter comes up, a question that is wholly evaded. In the same way the particular is constantly presupposed, whereas according to his doctrine it should always be shown to be composed of the abstract elements. Because the laws of mathematics are valid in the whole of existence, all phenomena are not therefore mere mathematical examples; because the laws of chemistry are not annulled, but on the contrary confirmed, by the investigation of organic beings, these do not become mere chemical products. The fundamental error here is always the confusion of cause and elementary condition.

By its original principle positivism is essentially empiricism. The positive was indeed determined in such a way that it coincided with the factually given, the phenomenal, the relative. Auguste Comte therefore declares materialism unscientific, because it sets up an absolute as the final ground of everything and thereby goes beyond the given. By the whole opposition in which he places positivism, as that which merely aims at [205] establishing the empirical connection of phenomena, over against metaphysics, as that which seeks the inner grounds, the essence of things in and for itself, Comte approaches

the skeptical empiricism that Hume founded. It was precisely from the denial of the validity of the concept of cause that Hume set out, and cognition became for him just such a connection of facts as Comte designates by positive philosophy. The well-known renewer of Hume's doctrine in our time, John Stuart Mill, was a disciple of Comte, whose view he interpreted and developed in an empirical-skeptical direction. But Mill counts it among Comte's faults that he never admits open questions. In particular he holds that, because positive knowledge can only show that in the universe, or rather in the part of the universe that we know, the phenomena are linked to one another in a determinate way, it therefore cannot deny the possibility that this whole lawful existence has its final ground in an eternal thought, provided only that one does not let this act in an arbitrary and lawless manner. What opinion one forms about this depends, according to Mill, on the significance one ascribes partly to the analogies that can be found in nature with conscious striving toward ends, partly to the general traditions of the human race^{*)}. Here a skepticism is introduced which turns against the very principle of positivism and reduces it to having only relative and conditioned validity. But when positivism can no longer maintain its own absolute validity, then the barrier that separated it from skepticism has also fallen.

Mill finds the explanation of certain extravagant doctrines in Comte's later writings in a tendency toward unity and systematizing which, in his opinion, is peculiar to French thinkers. This tendency makes itself felt in Comte's whole fundamental view; it was this that led him dogmatically to set up the proposition of the explanation of the concrete [206] by the elementary, whereby he passed over into materialism. This side of his doctrine was most emphasized by his French followers, especially by the best known among them, the learned naturalist and philologist Littré. Stuart Mill, on the other hand, parts from him also in the way in which the aim and essence of "positive" knowledge are more closely conceived. Whereas Comte seeks to abolish all particular phenomena by deriving them from their elements, Mill insists that the ultimate laws of nature that can be reached cannot be fewer in number than the qualitatively different sensations and states of consciousness (*sensations or other states of consciousness*); the limit must be set where the quantitative and gradual ends^{*)}. This determination of the limit of positive knowledge, too, points us in a quite different direction from the materialistic one.

But neither did Auguste Comte himself hold fast to that materialistic fundamental principle. When in »*Cours de philosophie positive*« he came to treat of organic beings, he set up a determination of the essence of the organism which recalls the Kantian one. With

^{*)}Auguste Comte and Positivism, p. 15.

^{*)}System of logic. 5 ed. II. p. 5.

inorganic beings, he says, the path of cognition goes from the parts to the whole; but with organic beings the true cognition of the parts must be derived from the cognition of the whole. What is peculiar to the organic being is namely that it is a closed unity that develops; the explanation of it must then show the ground of this unity and development. Analysis, which dissolves the whole into its elementary parts, is not sufficient here; analytic activity is only the preparation for the concluding cognition, which rests on a synthesis that grasps the whole. This now leads Comte to set up a proposition wholly opposed to that earlier one. The higher, he now says, explains the lower, not conversely. To derive and explain the higher from the lower is materialism. This he therefore now [207] rejects as unscientific, no longer because it goes beyond the empirical, but because it proceeds solely from the elementary.

The new law Comte sets up here he does not, however, apply at a point where its application seems precisely to lie close at hand, the relation between mind and body. Stuart Mill rightly reproaches him for having no place for a psychological science, but going straight from physiology over to sociology (the doctrine of human society). The reason for this is that he does not acknowledge a peculiar mental principle, but regards the mental merely as a product of the bodily. Here he remains true to his earlier fundamental principle: to derive the higher from the lower. Spiritual phenomena are at once more composite and more special than the physiological and physical ones. When, despite this intricate composition, a mental unity, an ego, shows itself, this is only an abstract concept which forms gradually through the feeling of the harmony and equilibrium which, in the normal state, forms among the manifold, mutually independent forces and functions in human nature. »*La notion du moi, c'est à dire, du consensus universel de l'ensemble de l'organisme*«. It is therefore futile to try to proceed from the ego, since this expresses only »*un état purement fictif*«; the true, which lies at the basis, is the elementary manifoldness.

Here too, however, the point is to hold fast to the reality of the unity as well as to that of the conditions. What Comte designates as »*purement fictif*« is the fundamental peculiarity of the human life of the spirit itself; it does not let itself be dismissed with a peremptory decree. It is not only in psychological respects that the concept of the ego, the unity of consciousness, is of decisive importance. The laws of human cognition point back to the inner organization of consciousness. When positivism regards cognition as a mere collecting and summarizing of factual phenomena and their mutual relations, then this is a purely mechanical and outward-directed activity, which with necessity [208] points back to an inner ground by which the mechanical is conditioned and from which

the activity proceeds. And this inner ground can be nothing other than the collecting and summarizing thought itself, whose laws become manifest in this collecting and summarizing working. That the law of thought is in itself one with the law of actuality is the final presupposition from which all scientific inquiry must proceed. Only then does cognition gain inner necessity and true unity. The unscientific character of positivism — we may here add: and of materialism — then consists, in the last instance, in its not investigating the first principles of science itself, not setting up a theory of cognition. But neither *can* it enter into these investigations without giving itself up; its essence is immediate dogmatism.

Philosophical criticism has to guard the universal laws and principles of science, especially against attempts to set up immediately as a scientific total view what has validity only in a single sphere, from the standpoint of a single science. Philosophy itself has at times believed that by virtue of its universal character it could master the separate sciences; in our day the opposite tendency prevails. Philosophical criticism turns against both one-sidednesses. It goes about, as Socrates once did, and asks those “who, because they can practice their own art in a fine manner, also think themselves wisest in other respects” how then they can give satisfaction with regard to the final grounds and concluding results of knowledge and science. Before this tribunal positivism and materialism prove their unreliability, — and it is before this tribunal that we also summon the author of the interesting lectures “on the relation between mind and body”; he too “practices his own art so finely” that he has supposed he could give satisfaction beyond its limits as well.

(To be continued.)

Harald Høffding.

Positivism and Materialism.

Imperfect as is the science of mind, I do not scruple to affirm, that it is in a considerably more advanced state than the portion of physiology which corresponds to it.

John Stuart Mill.

3.

It is not accidental that most of the spokesmen of materialism in our time are physicians and physiologists. The study of the human organism leads one to see how decisive a significance the bodily organs have for the whole spiritual life. La Mettrie became a materialist when, during a violent fever, he had had occasion to observe in himself the effect of the flow of blood on the brain; from that moment he regarded thinking as a mere consequence of the organization of "the bodily machine". According to *Système de la nature*, medicine solves the riddle of the human heart. Medicine has therefore been called the theology of materialism.

Yet it is far from the case that physiological study must of necessity lead to materialistic consequences. One need only look to men such as Flourens and Claude Bernard, Johannes Müller and Virchow to understand this. But in general those on the physiological side will speak out in a positivist direction. That Maudsley in particular stands [310] on the standpoint of positivism can easily be shown. True, he expressly invokes "the spirit of positivism" in only a single place; but that his whole way of looking at things is governed by this spirit is seen both from what he combats, from what he declares inaccessible to cognition, and from what he takes as his point of departure.

Science, he says, has inherited from theology the habit of regarding the mind as an incorporeal being that could not be apprehended through the senses. Thence arose "the metaphysical philosophy of mind", which did not take due account of the physical conditions under which mental life develops. One began where one ought to end, setting out the philosophy of mind according to the dubious revelations of self-consciousness, whereas it was precisely these revelations that were to be explained. The body was underestimated and despised, regarded as something one had to be ashamed of. Maudsley's efforts are therefore directed at freeing the problems from the fog in which metaphysics is supposed to have shrouded them.

In opposition to this it is insisted that the question of the nature of the mind is such that science cannot take hold of it at all, but that we are, and in all likelihood will always remain, completely ignorant in this respect. We can only feebly grope after the laws of its activity.

In what way, then, can its laws be found? Once the mind is no longer regarded as a non-sensible being, nothing stands in the way of applying the inductive method in the investigation of the mind just as in that of all other natural phenomena. We begin, then, with the simplest facts, namely the bodily conditions and expressions of the mind's activity. Anyone who would enrich our knowledge of mental life must in our day first and foremost explore the bodily conditions of its appearance in the healthy and in the diseased state. What we then gain by considering the simpler facts we use to explain the [311] more intricate and difficult ones. The higher functions of consciousness are developed from the lower, just as a peculiar and intricate structure is a development of a simpler and more general one. From the concrete we derive the abstract, from the uncompounded the compounded. The life of consciousness is the sum or product of a stream of forces to which every bodily organ sends its contributions, whether these are noticed or not. The sum must be resolved into its addends, the product into its factors, in order to be understood.

One sees that Maudsley shares Comte's conception of the history and character of science. The theological, the metaphysical, the positive period — this tripartition stands out clearly in what has just been cited. And just as Comte declared the essence of things in and for itself, or, as he mostly puts it, their causes, to be absolutely uncognizable, so Maudsley places the question of the nature of the mind outside science. What then remains as the task of science is to investigate the conditions, the laws of the mutual relations of things. Finally, Maudsley also agrees with Comte in the general proposition that the higher is to be derived from the lower, the elementary. But the manner in which Maudsley has conceived the principles of positivism, and the classic exposition of examples with which he illustrates them, give his lecture a peculiar interest. — We shall dwell first on the general principles before we pass on to the particulars.

The polemic against "metaphysics" is kept, as in Comte, rather indefinite, and it is therefore not easy to go more closely into it. On the one hand it seems as though metaphysics were meant to designate any answer whatsoever to the question of the essence and nature of things, thus here of the nature of the mind. But on the other hand Maudsley designates by that name in particular the spiritualist conception, which regards the soul as an immaterial being that is in itself independent of the bodily conditions.

But even then it is doubtful whether his polemic really hits the mark. It is precisely the spiritualists who have been most attentive to the significance of the bodily conditions; [312] the higher they raised the essence of the soul above the physical world, the stronger the influence that the bodily conditions exerted on it had to become. On this point spiritualists and materialists could splendidly agree. Plato, that father of spiritualism, teaches expressly that it is the constitution of the body that produces the diseases of the soul, that “no harmony and disharmony has greater influence on health and disease, virtue and vice, than that between the soul and the body”; — indeed, he goes as far as any of the most extreme materialists when he says that no one is bad by his own will, but that the “bad become bad through a diseased bodily constitution and through a bad upbringing”). And as regards the particular question of insanity, which is the one to which Maudsley ties his investigation of the relation between mind and body, it is precisely spiritualist thinkers (such as, e.g., the Frenchman Albert Lemoine) who in the most recent times have maintained that it must necessarily have a bodily cause, because they deny that the soul in itself can be diseased. — If, on the other hand, the polemic against metaphysics is to apply to every attempt at a solution of the problem of the nature of the mind, it applies to materialism just as much as to spiritualism and establishes an empirical skepticism. We have seen above that this skeptical element was characteristic of the point of departure of positivism.

But Maudsley holds fast to this skepticism as little as Auguste Comte did. Through the manner in which he applies the inductive method he arrives at an actual answer to the problem he at first rejected, “really takes hold of” the question of the nature of the mind — and to that extent becomes a metaphysician himself. There is no doubt that he is perfectly right to apply the inductive method in the investigation of mental life; but it depends on how the presuppositions for the application of the method are originally set up: an error here must necessarily, despite the most acute and exact carrying through of [313] the method, produce an error in the result. Now Maudsley commits from the beginning the error of regarding the elementary conditions of mental life and its rudimentary forms as the concrete and simple, from which consciousness in its various forms emerges by composition; the higher mental life is then designated, in relation to the elementary, as an abstraction. And yet it becomes clear from Maudsley’s own exposition that it is the reverse relation that is the true one. “It becomes necessary,” he says, “to separate out the lower and more elementary of these functions and from the concrete to derive, as well as possible, how the abstraction is to be understood.” But what is this separating

^{*)}Timæus. (Heise’s trans., pp. 138–141).

out other than an abstracting? The single function is drawn out of the whole connection in which it has its peculiar existence. The elementary that is separated out in this way becomes abstract. What Maudsley calls “the abstraction” is the total connection in which all single functions work, and which embraces and guides them, — a connection which at its highest stage of development is consciousness itself, the mind, insofar as it, to use Maudsley’s own expression, “gathers and comprehends the bodily life.” This gathering and comprehending presupposes a peculiar activity and proves that the mind is not merely an abstraction or a sum of forces. Through the total connection, which conditions the elementary functions just as much as these condition it, mental life proves itself to be something concrete and real in itself. And in thinking the active unity of the mind comes forth still more clearly. Every act of consciousness is in itself a single, indivisible act. — By turning attention away from this real unity of the mind and of consciousness, Maudsley has made the task unduly easy for himself, just as easy as he began by making it difficult when he declared the nature of the mind to be altogether incomprehensible. And not only this. Through the turn he has given the investigation, he has passed over into the materialistic conception of mental life. For it is the peculiarity of this conception [314] to posit the mental as the merely derived (sum, product, abstraction) and conditioned in relation to the bodily, and not to grant the former a peculiar essence of its own.

It is, as has been said, not the inductive method itself that leads to this result, but the presuppositions that are laid at the basis in its application, and into which determinations of deeply far-reaching significance are smuggled. Maudsley draws attention to “the realm of little things”, the infinitely fine nuances and movements that easily escape the investigator’s eye and yet can be of great significance. But in a logical respect he has himself overlooked the “little things” which, hidden in the presuppositions, appear in the consequences as very big things. At the outset he commits a logical, or if one will a metaphysical, mistake, which exerts its influence on the whole interpretation of the physiological results, but for which these are not to blame. The physiological investigations do not lose their value because the presuppositions for the concluding cognition, — a cognition that goes beyond the limit of physiology, — are false. — We shall now pass from the more general considerations to the particular, in order here too to investigate the relation between positive inquiry and the results at which it believes it has arrived.

It is from Pflüger’s and Flourens’s well-known experiments that Maudsley takes his point of departure, and it is the interpretation of these experiments that is at issue. A frog that has lost its head draws away the leg that one pinches, and hops away if the irritation

continues; if one cuts off the foot of the leg with which it rubs off a corrosive acid, it takes, after several vain attempts, the other leg to its aid. A pigeon from which one removes the hemispheres of the cerebrum loses, so to speak, its initiative, but nevertheless flies when one throws it into the air, closes its eyes against the light, and swallows the food one pushes into its mouth. Now are these so-called reflex movements or automatic actions mental or merely bodily? To ascribe them to the mind would in Maudsley's [315] opinion be a kind of anthropomorphism: it would "smack of the old, bad tendency that has done so much harm in philosophy, and that consists in explaining the facts of nature by what we feel in our own mind." On the other hand he infers from those experiments that actions with a definite aim can be altogether unconscious: "The animal has had deposited in its spinal cord the capacity to perform such movements for self-preservation as are given to it as a part of its nature, and without which it could scarcely live a day". In man, too, something similar shows itself. Not only are sneezing and coughing a reflex movement, a movement that, independently of the will, serves to remove what is harmful to the organism; but even the acts of will proper presuppose for their execution automatic actions proceeding from the motor centers of the spinal cord; for the how of the movement does not, after all, fall under the conscious will. And when a person repeatedly does something, the spinal cord is, as it were, trained to act on its own, so that the action is performed quite instinctively and automatically while consciousness itself is busy with entirely different things; so it is with many daily actions (dressing and undressing and the like). According to Maudsley it is no small part that is subtracted, by the doctrine of reflex movements, from the phenomena we are accustomed to regard as mental.

But the conclusion here does not seem to be as exact as the experiments from which it is drawn. So long as the one possibility stands beside the other, one cannot, after all, say that the answer is positive. Cuvier and Johannes Müller drew with full right the opposite conclusion from Flourens's experiments, namely that the animal, after having lost the hemispheres of the cerebrum, did indeed become dull and torpid, but nevertheless showed clear signs of actual sensation. How will Maudsley be able to refute this interpretation (which, remarkably enough, he does not even mention), since it has the signs on its side? All the more so since he would not be able to avoid coming to [316] something similar if one were to demand of him a closer explanation of the mystical expressions he would put in place of sensation and will: "capacity for self-preservation, to feel (*sic!*) and avoid what is harmful, as also to feel and strive (*sic*) after what is beneficial."

The fact is that Maudsley, through the “separating out” discussed above, which he did not see was an abstraction, has set a sharp distinction between the mental-conscious and the organic, unconscious life. But such a distinction cannot be maintained without manifold points of transition. Within sensation itself there is an infinite scale of stages leading from unconscious to conscious life. Conscious life therefore cannot be derived from unconscious life except by being presupposed in it as disposition and real possibility. There is an inner relation between the mental principle and its conditions, such that from the very first these enclose the principle within themselves, in order step by step to let it develop as they develop themselves. The degree of consciousness can thus vary; but when, as Maudsley himself concedes, one has before one actions “which in actuality bear the stamp of preceding consciousness and will”, there is no reason to think that consciousness should be entirely lacking^{*)}. Moreover, the automatic actions in man do, after all, exert a considerable influence on the life of consciousness itself; but how could that happen if they took place entirely outside consciousness? The mind cannot “gather and comprehend” what falls outside its domain.

[317] Maudsley does not stop at the mere reflex movements. What he believes he has gained here as a result, he seeks to apply to the higher mental functions. Despite the difference of the functions, he nevertheless holds that the properties and laws are essentially the same as in the lower nerve centers: “Impressions are received, upon these impressions there follows a reaction, and the effects both of the former and of the latter are ordered and preserved.” The impressions are the physiological conditions of *representations*. “The sensation of representations is *feeling*; for by feeling I understand the peculiar receptivity of the nervous substance to representations. That these are ordered and preserved is *memory*, and in the reaction they call forth, the *will* is given.”

Here, then, we have in brief what is to take the place of the “metaphysical philosophy of mind” that is supposed to have done so much harm. This much is certain, that these determinations are not metaphysical; it is another matter whether they therefore have less of the nebulous that, in Maudsley’s opinion, is peculiar to metaphysics.

The first thing that strikes the eye in those determinations is that it is not said at all what a representation is. It is only stated that the impressions are its physiological condition, and with that its essence is regarded as explained. This superficiality has

^{*)}Virchow uses the concept “unconscious sensation” to explain reflex movements. (Ueber das Rückenmark. Berlin 1871 p. 25). This indicates the right intermediate determination, when one remembers that sensation can never stand in complete opposition to consciousness. — He points out, moreover, that the influences that call forth reflex movements are propagated through the sensory nerves, and that there are, besides, also reflex movements caused by *conscious* sensations (e.g., contraction of the eyes on account of too dazzling a light).

its ground in the fact that, in order to explain the essence of representation, one must necessarily presuppose consciousness; but this Maudsley, who wants precisely to prove that consciousness arises as a sum or composition, cannot do. He therefore keeps to the empirical conditions and regards them as a sufficient explanation^{*)}. —The matter does not become clearer because it is said in another place that “representations are acquired through the senses, mixed, bound together, and grouped —and these organic combinations are the physiological conditions of the highest forms of our spiritual [318] activity: reflecting, reasoning, and judging.” Since we know beforehand only so much about representations, that they depend on physiological conditions, it is not easy to say what a mixing, binding together, and grouping of them is supposed to mean. Yet—when we further hear that these are “organic combinations” which in turn become “physiological conditions,” then the representations themselves can be nothing other than organic processes, and thus do not merely *depend* on such processes, since such a dependence does not exclude essential difference. With this the determination of feeling would agree: “the peculiar receptivity of the nervous substance to representations”—the representations must be something bodily in order to be able to affect the nervous substance. But the same difficulty recurs here: surely no one can seriously hold that from the receptivity of the nervous substance there follows the least thing toward the explanation of a phenomenon such as feeling, which is an inner state and presupposes a relation of the being to itself.

In the face of these difficulties Maudsley has no right to appeal to the uncognizability of the essence of the mind. For we have already seen earlier that he himself does not hold fast to this uncognizability. Nor does he do so in his physiological determinations. When it is said, e.g.: feeling is the receptivity of the nervous substance, etc., then this proposition appears with the same positive authority as his other doctrines. On the contrary, what follows from those difficulties is the necessity, in investigating mental phenomena, of taking one’s point of departure not merely in the physiological conditions but within the mental itself, in consciousness. And this is not a new and foreign point of departure. The life of consciousness, with its peculiar laws, points back, both through its successive development, its crises and diseases, and through its very end, the appropriation and development of the content of existence, to real, physical conditions as its foundation. The psychological in itself points toward the physiological. If, on the other hand, the physiologist does not have a clear consciousness of the peculiarity of the psychological, [319] the kernel of the question will escape him.

^{*)}“It is one question what a thing is, and another what it depends on”. Stuart Mill. *System of logic*. II p. 7 (5th. ed.)

That this consciousness is lacking in Maudsley is seen not least from his doctrine of memory. According to him, memory consists in an ordering and preserving of representations. But it is, he continues, a metaphysical error that memory should be peculiar to the mind. The acquired functions of the spinal cord and of the sensory ganglia cannot go on without memory; these organs would become idiotic if there were no memory in them. "In every nerve cell there is memory, and, what is more, it is found in every organic element of the body. The poison of smallpox or syphilis sets its mark on the body for the rest of life; we may forget it, but it does not forget us. The way in which the scar from a cut on the finger of a child persists and grows with the child's body proves that the organic constituents of the finger remember the change they have undergone. Memory is an ordered preservation of the effects that the impressions have called forth." But where are we now headed? Imperceptibly the first, psychological determination of memory is lost from sight, and all ordering and preserving of effects of impressions is made into memory. No account is taken of the essential difference between the way in which representations are stored in consciousness and the way in which effects are preserved in the organism. A name that is carved in the bark of a tree is surely not preserved by the tree in the way it is preserved by the one whose "dear, constant thought" it is. One of two things: either Maudsley must here, in the manner of a poet, make the tree into an ensouled being with remembrance and sympathy, or else he must make consciousness into a purely mechanical container. What produces the unclarity is that memory is unthinkable unless the organic elements retain the movement corresponding to the remembered representation, or rather its possibility. But this organic movement is not the representation itself, only its condition. In the organic

[320] element the movement corresponding to the representation is "remembered" in the same way as the scar in the boy's finger, the name in the tree's bark; in consciousness the representation is remembered as a moment in the whole world of thought that is the content of consciousness, and it is remembered with an intensity that depends on its significance in this content. Such words as impression, order, collecting therefore acquire a different meaning according to the side from which one views the matter. But the positivist, who overlooks this, comes not only to speak physiologically where he ought to speak psychologically, but also psychologically where he ought to speak physiologically—and thereby goes back from the "positive" standpoint to the "metaphysical," indeed perhaps even to the "theological," in that he explains natural phenomena after the analogy of his own essence.

No more than memory is the will, according to Maudsley, a peculiarly mental phe-

nomenon. For it is, says he, a fundamental peculiarity of all organized tissues that they strive after what is beneficial and shun what is harmful to them. The impulses that arise from this property of the tissues we call manifestations of will when they are guided by reason. —Apart from the difficulty, already mentioned earlier, of conceiving what it is supposed to mean that an organized tissue strives, shuns, and impels—there is this peculiarity about this determination of the will, that the decisive factor is introduced as a condition that is not explained. What distinguishes the will from mere drive is, to be sure, that it is guided by reason; but then it must first and foremost be shown of what kind this relation between reason and the drive-impulse is, and how it is possible. How can the impulses at once be called forth by the properties of the organized tissues and “according to reflection be guided by reason”? This question, which psychologically is the main question, Maudsley does not raise at all, any more than we get to know what he understands by reason. He thereby comes to lack a real standard for the relation between the reflex movements and the proper manifestations of will; for when, in the case of the latter, one sets aside the element of reason or consciousness, they certainly do not become different from the former. [321]

One can, it is further said, speak physiologically only of manifestations of will; the *will*, as something different from the individual actions, is a metaphysical abstraction. —Whether there really is anyone who has wanted to place the will outside the actions must surely be doubted; Maudsley’s polemic is here, as on other points, not free from itself producing the opponent it combats. The same polemic could in any case be directed against him himself. The fundamental peculiarity he assumes in the organized tissues likewise becomes, when his manner of consideration is applied, merely a “metaphysical abstraction”; for it manifests itself only under the influence of determinate agencies. But what does one understand by will other than the fundamental peculiarity of mental life to which the manifestations of will point back? Positive inquiry, which keeps to the factual effects in order through them to come to know the essence of things, cannot, after all, as Maudsley’s own example shows, avoid leading the effects back to the essence as possibilities contained in it. This is perhaps metaphysical; but then it is a metaphysics to which physics itself leads us. If one wants to say, e.g., that we do not know the essence of electricity, this must be restricted to this: that we know electricity insofar as we know how it acts under determinate circumstances. We know, after all, that the electric current forms a link between the different natural activities, since by it one can produce light and heat, magnetic and chemical activities, and conversely the current from these;

and one can measure the electric current by its chemical or magnetic effect^{*)}. Should this not be a contribution to the cognition of the nature of electricity? If one seeks the [322] essence or nature outside the manifestations, one is guilty of a false metaphysics. We have indeed witnessed the strange spectacle that a thinker like Stuart Mill has written a book on the position of woman in society that contains the most ingenious and most apt characterization of woman—but in which he nevertheless maintains from first to last that we know nothing of the nature of woman!

4.

Partly as a means of further elucidating what he has developed about the relation between mind and body in general, partly as a particular application of it, Maudsley enters upon an investigation of the essence of mental illnesses and their relation to other nervous disorders. These investigations are the most interesting and most instructive in his lecture; they are also those in which he most avoids an unfortunate overstepping of the boundary of his science and thereby also of his competence. When we nevertheless attempt here too to apply a critique, it must, even more than on other points, be kept in mind that this critique proceeds solely from a psychological point of view and therefore cannot detract in any way from the significance that Maudsley's investigations may have in a medical respect.

The usual conception and classification of mental illnesses does not satisfy Maudsley, because it proceeds exclusively from a psychological standpoint. The true scientific spirit, "the spirit of positivity," is in his opinion satisfied only when one holds fast to the fact that these disorders rest on the same conditions as other diseases. Since mental life is so closely bound to and dependent on the bodily functions, mental illness cannot be a purely mental phenomenon either; it is not a disease of a metaphysical concept, but a nervous disease with predominantly mental symptoms. This view is of course not new; among us, [323] for instance, F. G. Howitz already urged it in his treatise "om Afsindighed og Tilregnelser" (1824), where insanity is defined as "a restriction of reason or of the use of reason owing to a disease in the material organs of the mind's activity," as "brain sickness," and where weight is therefore laid on the double (mental and bodily) investigation and determination of it. But what is peculiar to Maudsley's investigation is the closer grounding and the further consequences.

^{*)}C. V. Holten: *Om Virksomhedernes Omdannelse i Naturen*. 1868. (University program). p. 19.

One does not know at all the movements in the parts of the brain that are the physical conditions of mental activity, or the chemical changes that accompany them, any more than one can demonstrate any difference between the nerve elements of the tired, exhausted brain and of the revived, refreshed one. The means of investigation do not suffice in the face of changes that are finer than the microscopic. "We might almost as well set about studying the anatomy of a gnat with a telescope." Thus the brains of deceased mentally ill persons have been found entirely normal. But according to Maudsley one must not conclude from this that the change is not there; it may well exist, even if it belongs to "the realm of infinitely small things," which is inaccessible to our senses. By virtue of the close connection between mind and body and of the bodily symptoms that accompany mental illness, a disease in the brain *must* be assumed.

The justification of this inference, however, does not stand quite unchallenged. One must, in the first place, wonder that Maudsley takes no account of the cases, which have been established, in which both anterior lobes of the cerebrum were diseased and destroyed to a considerable degree, and in which nevertheless not the slightest disturbance of the intelligence was observed^{*)}. And next, one will be able to set against Maudsley's line of thought another, apparently more scientifically sober one, that of the [324] French physiologist Leuret. Certainly, says the latter, I have no right to conclude that there is no change because I cannot see any; but with the same caution I must guard against concluding that there *is* one. When the brain of an insane person appears to be healthy, I do not conclude that this brain is diseased, but I remain in doubt until the truth is proven. And if the cases in which the brain appears to be healthy are precisely those in which the insanity is not accompanied by bodily symptoms but is an aberration of the understanding and the passions, while the cases in which the brain is altered are those in which paralysis, dullness, and sleeplessness have occurred, then I ascribe the brain damage to these circumstances, and the cause of the derangement of mind remains unknown^{*)}.

This much at least seems to follow from this, that drawing too hasty conclusions in this field is attended with the greatest hazards. But in any case—the correctness of the claim that there is always a bodily cause granted—has one thereby gained a closer insight into the essence of mental illness, and must this not still be understood primarily from the psychological side? Maudsley himself remarks that the mental symptoms are the predominant ones. But how can one demonstrate an inner connection between them and the bodily symptoms? It has rightly been said that when a clock strikes wrongly

^{*)}Longet cites two such cases. See Lange: Geschichte der Materialismus. p. 431.

^{*)}Revue des deux mondes. 15 juillet 1865. p. 417.

because a wheel is broken, it does not follow that it was this wheel that struck;—we do not know the nature or operation of a locomotive because we know that it cannot do service when it is broken. The connection between the mental and bodily symptoms becomes a purely empirical one, whereas within mental life we can follow insanity step by step from the first faint signs to the demonically overwhelming power with which [325] it appears at its height. Here the laws of the association of ideas, of thought, and of character come to our aid — but the study of these laws is a psychological study. The physician of the mentally ill must therefore above all be a practical psychologist.

Maudsley does not seek the bodily cause of insanity in an influence from without, through a spiritual shock or bodily injury; such an influence is only the occasion. The real root of mental illness lies deeper, in an innate disposition, in the organization of the individual's nervous system. When two people are exposed to the same spiritual shock, and the one of them becomes insane while the other only for a moment loses his equilibrium, the reason for this can only be that in the former there is a factor in play which is not found in the latter — some innate nervous disease or other. Should one hold that this need not after all be innate, but could have formed under the influence of the circumstances of life, Maudsley rejects this in the following way: "Of all the erroneous conceptions of the mind which metaphysics has begotten or been complicit in, there is perhaps none that is more false than that which tacitly assumes or expressly declares that all men are born with equally good conditions for the development of a mental life, while circumstances and education condition the differences in later development". Poor metaphysics, which now, besides its own sins, must also take the offenses of materialism upon its shoulders, and is thus here accused of the very opposite of what was brought forward against it above! Still, it is not ours to defend it here. We shall instead see what Maudsley sets up in opposition to what he lays to its charge. "Education can certainly accomplish much, and the circumstances of life can also accomplish much; but we must not forget that the foundation on which the yield of education must rest is not acquired but inherited. No one can escape being ruled by his organism, no one can flee the fate he is born with". The innate is thus inherited, and the inherited fund of forces that man [326] brings with him to the battle of life conditions the success with which he fights it out. The life of the mind, like all life, is placed among forces that always seek to annihilate it, and against which it must therefore constantly be on a war footing. He who can master circumstances gets ahead; the weak man is mastered by them and collapses — and one of the ways in which his misfortunes can show themselves is precisely as mental illness. "Thus it comes about that mental trials, which serve to strengthen a vigorous nature,

break down a weak nature that cannot offer due resistance; the circumstance that a moral cause can bring on a mental illness betrays a conspiracy from within with the unfavorable outward circumstances.”

We inherit as a natural gift what our forefathers have acquired, both the good and the evil. The moral sense arises in that what the one generation attains of conscious cognition of what is beneficial or harmful to humanity is, by virtue of the organization of the nervous system (cf. above on memory), passed down by inheritance to the next generation as “a natural or instinctive susceptibility that belongs to his brain when it has its proper structure”. What has been acquired piece by piece is put together so closely that it finally seems to constitute one single, indivisible faculty. By following the history of humanity back, one would finally, at the starting point, find “a state which, whether one would call it apeline or human, lacked any real moral feeling.” The physiological proof of this is supposed to lie in the progressive development of the human brain; the part of the tissue that has been added represents the experiences and recollections of the race, which have been incorporated in us. But it is only when the normal presuppositions are present that the moral sense is inherited. If the structure of the brain is not the proper one, if the individual has “the insane temperament”, then it is precisely that sense, the highest flower of culture, that is lost first. If this abnormality persists through several generations, idiocy appears. He who is born an idiot has lost his birthright as a human being and sinks back to the animal stage. Of particular interest here are the “theroid idiots”, in whom not only animal instincts but also an animal-like appearance occur — traits which are as it were echoes from a vanished time, testimony to a kinship that man has almost outgrown and is too proud to acknowledge. In such failed and degenerate individuals, then, the result that was won is lost, and its original, unworked element comes forth again. Thus the psychology of mental illnesses confirms Darwin’s view, pointing back to it as to the only thorough explanation. [327]

It is with a certain necessity that Maudsley concludes his investigations by referring to Darwinism, this bold, concluding view of modern natural science. But it is not thereby said that this reference is one with an explanation. Darwinism has a certain indeterminacy in its essence; it can be understood from two sides. That all organic forms have developed from one primordial form can namely either mean that all those forms are only expressions of the different ways in which the primordial form was mechanically affected and modified by the outer conditions, or that they were originally contained as dispositions and possibilities in the primordial form, so that this form encompassed in itself, as in a germ, the whole world of living beings. In the latter case Darwinism

becomes no particularly positivistic or materialistic doctrine. For the higher forms are then so disposed from the first and, as dispositions, have an ideal superiority over the conditions, which become only the means of their actualization. And if one notes that the real main factor in Darwin is not the outer conditions but what he calls the struggle for life, it seems reasonable that this latter conception of Darwinism must be the right one. For a struggle for life there is required an actual principle of life, where energy can be concentrated, from which the struggle can be waged. There must be something for whose preservation and development the struggle is waged; without such an *original* good the struggle would have led to nothing. Out of nothing comes nothing.

[328]

But Maudsley starts precisely from an original nothing, from a zero point. The development of the race is supposed to have begun at a stage where any real moral feeling was lacking. Only gradually are the fragments gathered from which the moral sense is put together in such a way that it can finally appear as an indivisible faculty. But the very appropriation and working-up of these fragments presupposes an activity, a laboring, a “gathering and comprehending” — in short, a working whose possibility we cannot see if there is not something originally at work. In psychological respects Maudsley starts from the view that the English philosophers of the present day (Stuart Mill, Herbert Spencer) have developed as an inheritance from their great predecessor in the last century, David Hume — the view, namely, according to which the laws and the whole development of the life of consciousness rest on the associations of ideas, according to which the empirically received representations group themselves. The representations, once grouped and received, gradually become a lasting part of the mental constitution and pass by inheritance from the one generation to the next, so that for following generations they present themselves as truths valid in themselves or assert themselves as immediate instincts. But this doctrine of the growth of the understanding (*growth of intelligence*) overlooks that the essential, lawful connection which is peculiar to the content of thinking consciousness cannot have arisen through a mere accumulation of representations or through the constancy of impressions from without. The inner lawfulness is the fruit of a labor of thought which necessarily presupposes a laboring thought, whose essence is one with the universal reason in existence. Without this, the ultimate principle of all human cognition, all knowledge would be impossible. And besides, since the immediate truths in the course of time become objects of criticism, since consciousness can thus turn against its own work in order to annihilate it, there must be an inner unity in the self, if it is not to perish under such criticism but is to be able to work its way forward to new expressions of the truth.

The moral sense is not one with what at a particular time and place constitutes its [329] content. Maudsley here himself becomes guilty of what he reproaches “metaphysics” with: ascribing too much to the outward. The properly moral is essentially a relation between self-consciousness on the one side and its content and conditions on the other, but it does not consist in this or that particular content. The Australian negro therefore has a moral sense just as well as the European most developed in intelligence. But the positivistic and materialistic way of viewing becomes guilty of much superficiality with respect to such questions. When, for example, one finds among a savage people no belief in particular gods or any cult properly so called, the conclusion is at once drawn that this people lacks religiousness, without one’s investigating whether the religious does not express itself in another way among this people, whether it does not, for example, merge with the relation of piety toward chieftains and fathers, who thus become a kind of earthly gods. Or one denies certain savage peoples the capacity for cognition because one does not find general, scientific propositions expressed in their language.

Further, there hides beneath the expression “heredity” an ambiguity. A content of consciousness cannot be directly inherited; it must be appropriated anew by each generation. Here there can only be talk of immediate inheritance insofar as the growing generation, through education, takes up without criticism what the preceding one hands over to it; even after criticism has awakened, it can be difficult to free oneself from the immediately received impressions. What, on the other hand, is directly innate, as a part of the individual’s original constitution, can only be more or less favorable dispositions and drives. As the essential thing about the cultivated moral sense is an ethical *How*, so the essential thing about the innate possibility is an organic-psychic *How*. It is really only here that Darwin’s theory finds its application — an application that lies plain to see, and which Plato already made in his “Republic”, where he in a sense appears as Darwin’s [330] forerunner^{*)}. The innate possibility does not lead directly to the goal; it presupposes the individual’s own striving and is not actualized if the individual will not take the matter into his own hands. Admittedly the higher development of energy acts back on the organic-psychic foundation that passes by inheritance; this is plainly seen in the noble families. But still it is not the happily developed brain; it is only the conditions for its happy development that can be inherited.

Maudsley does not apply the same way of viewing to the race as to the individual. As regards the latter, he maintains the significance of the innate foundation in opposition to the effect of outer influences; but in the case of the whole race he thinks he does not

^{*)}Plato’s Republic. Book 5. (Heise’s transl. of the Republic. Part 2, pp. 24–27).

need such an original foundation; there he ascribes an overwhelming significance to the outer influences. And yet one will hardly be able to maintain such an opposed way of viewing; one must necessarily apply a kindred standard in both places, as surely as the essence of the race cannot be heterogeneous with that of the individual. The German materialist Büchner is more consistent here than the English positivist; he will not even concede a peculiar, innate foundation for the life of consciousness, for fear that “innate ideas” should be smuggled in under this form. If Maudsley thinks that on grounds of experience he must hold to the significance of the innate as regards the individual, he must also do so as regards the race.

But the innate cannot in any case be said without further ado to be one with the individual's fate, so that this fate is settled at birth. Fate in the true sense, the ethical fate, the result of the interaction between the individual's conscious striving and the inner
 [331] and outer conditions, cannot be innate. Conscious striving is, even if it must succumb to unfavorable conditions as to the power of natural necessity, an ethical reality. Only the purely idiotic existence is immediately determined by the innate foundation; but this existence then also lacks the proper distinguishing mark of the human. Maudsley rightly declares that the idiot is robbed of his birthright as a human being, since he is born with such a deficiency of brain that he cannot perform any mental function at all, or can do so only imperfectly. But how one must be astonished on reading his following words: “He (the idiot) himself bears no blame for this visitation, since he has committed no other offense than that of having his share in human sinfulness.” What can this mean, if it is not a mere remnant of a theological metaphysics? To have a share in sinfulness and yet not to have committed any offense, indeed even to lack the possibility of it, since one is from the very outset robbed of one's birthright as a human being! Sinfulness can no more be inherited than the moral sense can. Such a way of viewing leads to a complete confusion of medical and moral concepts. The counterpart to the idiot's sinfulness is formed by the conception of crime as mental illness or epilepsy.

And yet the latter conception is more correct than the former; it requires only a closer determination. One must not here confuse the legal and the moral standpoint. The crime can well be present legally without being so morally. One can imagine an existence which, even if it has not lost its birthright as a human being, has nevertheless arisen and developed under circumstances that, with the power of a natural necessity, must have forced back everything higher and nobler, where original disposition and outward lot have worked together to such a degree that the criminal act can almost be said to come as a necessary product of them, without there having been any possibility

for the individual's own laboring, since consciousness has not been able to awaken at all. Such an individual can be legally punishable and yet morally excusable: legally, [332] one proceeds from the relation of the single individual to society and society's right over against him; morally, the gaze is directed solely at the relation between conscious striving and the conditions. But the common conception sees the matter in such a way that a criminal offense is a higher degree of a merely moral transgression; it does not see that the properly ethical moment can often be wholly subordinate in what is legally punishable. Here, then, society can be within its right in holding to the legal way of viewing; but the moral one must not be overlooked either: it enjoins at once a reconciling conception of the "criminal" and points to where the real difference between good and evil comes forth. The medical way of viewing is indisputably right over against the legal one when it maintains "that a considerable part of criminals are feeble-minded or epileptic or come from families in which there is mental illness, epilepsy, or some other nervous disease". But it often becomes guilty of the same confusion as the vulgar way of viewing, only in another manner. Because doubt can be raised about the moral accountability of criminal offenses in certain cases, this accountability is not therefore abolished altogether. As if it found application only where there is legal talk of crime!

Maudsley defines the physician's standpoint as the practical one, where mind and body are regarded as a unity of essence; only purely theoretically can one separate the mind from the body and immerse oneself in self-consciousness. In practical respects we perhaps also come to agree with him more than in theory. It is beyond all doubt that the physician is called, and will ever more and more be called, to a practical office of the greatest humane significance. But precisely for that reason it is also of the greatest significance that his cultivation and way of seeing do not become one-sided. By the practical standpoint Maudsley seems to understand the physiological in opposition to what he calls the metaphysical. And yet the physiological standpoint too is still only a theoretically one-sided one when it is not combined with an actual, living psychological [333] insight; this has been amply shown in the foregoing. The physician does indeed often acquire such a psychological insight, since through close attention to the states of the body he also sharpens his eye for the observation of the mental; but penetrating and complete it can only become when the psychological is recognized as a circle of laws and conditions peculiar in itself, which is not merely an imprint of the bodily states. But things do not yet seem to have come that far. "It is rare," says Stuart Mill, "to find a physician who is also a psychologist." Even the founder of positivism, Auguste Comte, shared this opinion; he regarded physicians only as veterinarians, because they concern

themselves solely with man's animal, not with his human, nature.

The truly practical standpoint here too points back to the true theory, in that it demands that all considerations be respected. Therefore positivism and materialism, which have grasped only one side of life and of the essence of existence and are thus one-sided in theory, cannot lead to the true practice either.

Harald Høffding.
